



The Most Dangerous School Runs in the World **Comprehension Questions**

1. Why do you think the author begins the text with a rhetorical question?

2. What words or phrases can you find in the article that suggest danger or difficulty?

3. What makes Syria so dangerous for students?

4. Why might the author have used the subheading 'Dangers of a Different Kind'?

5. Explain the effectiveness of two layout features in the text. You might consider headings, subheadings, text boxes or image choices.

6. What do you think the author's personal view on education for all people is? What evidence do you have for this?



7. How might children in Chile and Myanmar get to school?

8. Explain what you think a 'non-legally binding instrument' is, based on the text of the article.

9. Who has documented the journey across the Zaskar River in the Himalayas?

10. List three challenges for children journeying to school in the Pamir mountain region.

Extension

- One pupil wrote 'The author of the article seems to be deeply troubled by the difficulties faced by some children around the world.' To what extent do you agree with this assessment?
- Research one of the dangerous school runs mentioned in the article. What more can you find out?
- The article talks about the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Find out more about the document and the United Nations in general. There is a specific branch of the UN that oversees the rights of children. What rights should all children around the world have? Do you agree with those chosen by the UN? Why or why not?



The Most Dangerous School Runs in the World **Comprehension - Answers**

1. Why do you think the author begins the text with a rhetorical question?

The author attempts to make the reader consider their own reasonably simple route to school. This will encourage interest and empathy with the children in the article.

2. What words or phrases can you find in the article that suggest danger or difficulty?

There are a number including 'no easy feat' and 'arduous'.

3. What makes Syria so dangerous for students?

Syria has been in a civil war since 2011. There are reports of over 4,200 attacks on schools and many children are killed while travelling to school.

4. Why might the author have used the subheading 'Dangers of a Different Kind'?

The subheading connects the previous natural difficulties with those in this section (man-made dangers including war and crime).

5. Explain the effectiveness of two layout features in the text. You might consider headings, subheadings, text boxes or image choices.

Answers will vary here; credit anything that attempts to explain effect.

6. What do you think the author's personal view on education for all people is? What evidence do you have for this?

Answers may vary but reference to the first and last sections of the article should be made by students. The author highlights the usefulness of education in bringing about economic growth to poor areas, thus indicating there is a need for it. The writer also reminds the reader how easy education is for many of us, showing a respect for those who go out of their way to reach school: 'Next time you are bemoaning your long walk or delayed train, consider what you might have to endure had you been born in an alternative environment in another part of the world.'

7. How might children in Chile and Myanmar get to school?

Children might reach school by mule (Chile) or bull (Myanmar).

8. Explain what you think a 'non-legally binding instrument' is, based on the text of the article.

Answers may vary but some understanding that it means it 'encourages' rather enforces governments. The author writes that it has huge 'political and moral gravitas'.

9. Who has documented the journey across the Zaskar River in the Himalayas?

BBC's *Human Planet* programme.

10. List three challenges for children journeying to school in the Pamir mountain region.

Challenges include: walking 50 miles on foot or camel; scaling 1,000 foot cliffs; trekking on a narrow path cut into a cliff face; wading through four freezing rivers and zip lining 600 feet through the air.



Extension

- One pupil wrote 'The author of the article seems to be deeply troubled by the difficulties faced by some children around the world.' To what extent do you agree with this assessment?

Answers will be varied but students should attempt to use evidence from the text to help their response.

- Research one of the dangerous school runs mentioned in the article. What more can you find out?

Students might watch one of the highly interesting and informative videos on YouTube. A search for *Dangerous School Runs* shows many interesting results including quick summary programmes and more in-depth material.

- The article talks about the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Find out more about the document and the United Nations in general. There is a specific branch of the UN that oversees the rights of children. What rights should all children around the world have? Do you agree with those chosen by the UN? Why or why not?

Students might create a fact file about the UN Convention on the Rights of a Child. There are 12 rights in total. Use the UNCRC website as a starting point: <https://www.unicef.org.uk/what-we-do/un-convention-child-rights/>. Students might have a lively debate about what else should be included or what they think is redundant in the Convention. Are these rights noticeable in the world today? What about in Britain? Students might also look at the addresses of the UN of Malala Yousafzai and others in relation to education for girls and women.